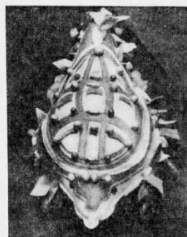
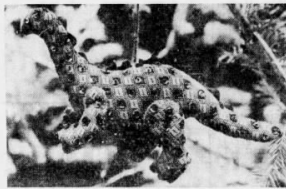
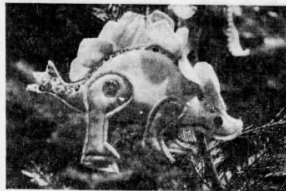


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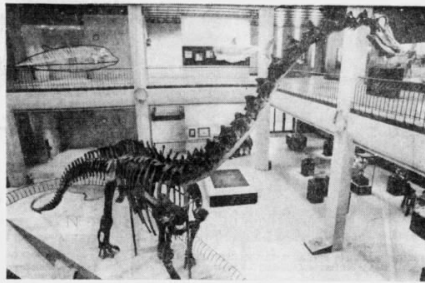
Dinosaurs' First Christmas

Photos by Tom Collins, Chronicle Staff

The Creative Stitchers of Houston have put up a "dinosaur tree" at the museum, one of 12 unusual Christmas trees.



On and around the tree are carefully reproduced, authentic soft sculpture dinosaurs like stegosaurs (second from top), a sauropod (above), and ankylosaurus (left).



The newest, and biggest, star at the Houston Museum of Natural Science is diplodocus, a dinosaur that's 78 feet long from head to tail.



Dinosaur kits are sold out for now, but more are expected in the museum gift shop after Christmas. Two different kits (shown here) will be offered — prehistoric and triassic, which are larger than the dinosaur tree ornaments.

In honor of the newly completed dinosaur skeleton, Diplodocus, at the Museum of Natural Science, the Creative Stitchers of Houston have prepared the ultimate tribute — a "dinosaur tree" for the museum's annual Christmas tree parade.

Who said dinosaurs can't climb trees?

Each of the soft sculpture dinosaurs is an original, hand-made design, scientifically accurate and executed by an experienced craftsman. Some of the little lizards will be for sale in the museum in January.

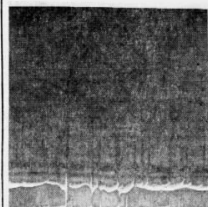
The "dinosaur tree" is one of 12 unusual Christmas trees decorated by civic organizations for the museum's "Sights and Sounds of Christmas" exhibit which will be open through Jan. 5.

Chairs which will ring at the museum during the rest of the holiday season are: Dec. 20, Interfaith Gospel Singers; Dec. 21, Kinkaid 2nd grade Browne choir; Dec. 22, San Jacinto Girl Scout Bicentennial choir. The guild of the Museum of Natural Science, which sponsors the exhibit, decorated a tree called "A Starry Salute" and stars of red, white and blue gingerbread to salute the Bicentennial.

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